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04/20/2025

The Role of Social Media in the Development of Adolescents

There is no question the internet has become a major part of the current generation's childhood. As spoken about in *The Anxious Generation* by Jonathon Haidt, there has been a "great rewiring," which is a term that references the transformation to a phone-based childhood (114). It's not just a term that people should worry about, the Pew Research Center has shown strong evidence to give this term credibility. In 2024, they found that 96% of the adolescents surveyed used the internet daily, and almost half of those surveyed use the internet "almost constantly" (Pew Research Center, 2024). Another phenomenon that can't be denied is the rise in anxiety and depression in adolescents over the past decade. This is acknowledged by Justine Murison, who says that anxiety is "one of the leading mental health diagnoses for adolescents," and there has been a rise in prescriptions of anxiety medications (13). While this is partly due to the COVID-19 pandemic, there seems to be a connection between the rise of social media use in adolescents and the rise in anxiety. In this essay, I claim that social media has caused a rise in anxiety, hindered well-being and development, and propose a policy to mediate this.

I start the essay by defining key terms about anxiety, social media, and adolescents. Then, I give a deeper description of the problem, highlighting how the changing brain of adolescents can be exploited and how their relationships are affected. Next, I evaluate the problem using ethical theory. By explaining the Ethics of Care and Kantianism, the problem and the proposed policy are defended. I then explain the policy, which outlines two approaches to solving the problem. Finally, I respond to an objection to the argument that concerns the development of adolescence's identity.

This section of the essay will focus on defining terms, specifically those related to anxiety and social media. Also, adolescence in this essay refers to the same age range discussed in most papers, which is any age under adulthood, but particularly ages 10-14, as that is typically when certain anxieties manifest and internet usage increases (Runcan, 115). With that said, I can continue to define anxiety. Remus Runcan quotes language dictionaries when saying anxiety is defined as “a nervous disorder marked by excessive uneasiness [...] and apprehension [...], typically with compulsive behavior or panic attacks” (113). De Rutte et al. focus on a specific byproduct of anxiety, called the “anxiety-related attention bias”, that is defined as “selective and exaggerated attention to threat” (164). Social comparison consists of comparing oneself to another entity online, with upper social comparison denoting comparisons towards those that appear superior and the opposite for downward social comparison (de Rutte et al, 168). Those are the definitions for anxiety mentioned in this essay. Social media can be defined as a platform for people to connect with others, post content on the platform, and share content with others. Most papers do not define social media, which I assume is because they see it as common knowledge in this day and age. De Rutte et al. define computer-mediated forms of communication (CMC) as “social media, texting, emailing, video-conferencing, and other types of communication conducted via digital technologies” (160). As the important terms have been defined, the problem can be explored more deeply.

When trying to define a connection between hindered development and social media use, multiple sources can be pointed to for guidance on what this connection is and what it does. To begin, social media is made to grab and keep attention (de Rutte et al, 161). As a business model, this makes sense; if the interactions with users drive profit and growth, then keeping the user’s attention should be top priority. However, this exploits the adolescent mind. The adolescent brain

is undergoing extreme change as neurons develop or are pruned if not used (Valkenburg and Piotrowski, 80). They begin to question the world and think more critically about their surroundings. As a result of this change, they begin to prefer media that keeps up with the rapid thought processes they now possess. This is not abnormal, as “entertainment programs” should not be too different from the “cognitive skills” they possess (Valkenburg and Piotrowski, 83). Several social media platforms thrive on short, quick, and accessible content, namely Snapchat (a limited-time photo messaging application), TikTok (a short-form video application), and Instagram (a picture and short-form video messaging application). Also, Snapchat specializes in quick interactions with people by sending them pictures, often without saying anything, and you can see when someone has opened your message. These are examples of CMCs, and multiple features about them create a demanding link between them and adolescents. With apps like Snapchat, adolescents associate this app with short connections with others. Through TikTok and Instagram, users are rewarded for using the app by seeing who liked their post or seeing something entertaining. Either way, this creates a “compulsive or habitual” behavior over time (de Rutte et al, 162). As adolescents create their identity and build self-esteem, getting likes or interacting with others becomes a major reassurance about who they are (Valkenburg and Piotrowski, 88). Thus, social media uses the fragile identity of adolescents to keep them using the application in an addictive manner that affects their emotional development and well-being.

Furthermore, the use of social media seems to affect their ability to create and sustain relationships. Adolescents’ relationships are undoubtedly “complex, interconnected, and multifaceted,” making it difficult to point to one thing that affects them (Véronneau and Schwartz-Mette, 487). Also, several features make online interactions different from offline interactions, such as the “asynchrony of interactions,” the lack of nonverbal cues, and the

“quantifiability” of “social metrics” (Véronneau and Schwartz-Mette, 490). Véronneau and Schwartz-Mette claim that adolescents using social media for their interactions “affect them in a different way than their offline peer interactions” (491). The *affiliation* with certain cliques can negatively impact adolescents’ well-being, as those who do not have a strong connection with others in offline relationships use social media as a form of social gratification or to find others not available to them in an offline world (Véronneau and Schwartz-Mette, 491). The latter can prove to be a benefit for the growth of identity, but it poses risks to adolescents’ ability to create new relationships outside of social media. What seems to be a grave issue is how social media impacts adolescents’ aggression. Because social media provides a solid boundary between two people interacting, it is often easier to say difficult or harmful words than in an in-person interaction. While this has benefits for certain aspects of intimacy, it provides a ground for hateful speech and bullying to grow. It is understood that this aggression is not the main purpose of using social media, but its consequences are serious and can lead to offline aggression (Véronneau and Schwartz-Mette, 492). Subrahmanyam and Greenfield also explored adolescents’ relationships with respect to the internet in 2008. While they found that most adolescents found it beneficial based on a self-assessment of well-being, they also acknowledged the prevalence of bullying that existed in the early days of the internet and online communication (125-128). It is also worth noting that there is a possibility of adolescents not talking about their issues with online relationships. Because there is a strong juxtaposition between communication online and offline, adolescents might find it too difficult to talk about these issues in person and defer to online communication. These issues with relationships and how people can easily impact a person’s well-being through online communication represent a detriment of social media.

This problem of how adolescents are affected by social media can be evaluated well and explained by the ethics of care. As discussed in Virginia Held's book, *The Ethics of Care*, the theory outlines how autonomous beings have certain moral obligations with respect to care, emotional, and the well-being of others. It recognizes moral value and the need for moral guidance (Held, 12). The theory "addresses rather than neglects moral issues [...] in relations among the unequal and dependent, relations that are often laden with emotion," and how this impacts society (Held, 13). With this concept in mind, I want to focus on the word 'dependent'. Whether adolescents agree with this notion or not, they are dependent on the adults in their lives. They are still being cared for, ideally provided with food and shelter, and are subject to their parents' rules, whether they choose to follow them or not. According to the ethics of care, it is our responsibility as independent, autonomous adults to guide the dependent adolescents through this difficult and complex online world. If there is a solution to this problem, then, according to the ethics of care, we are morally obligated to follow this solution to aid the development of adolescents. The ethics of care values "empathetic responsiveness" and "needs are responded to" in practice (Held, 15-16). By this theory, we must respond to the adolescent's need for guidance and aid so they do not hinder their development as humans. Thus, the solution we propose would be responding to those needs. The solution will be discussed in more detail in the next section, but it outlines teaching adolescents how to use social media and calls on social media platforms to make their interfaces less addictive. This solution is satisfactory in the eyes of the ethics of care because it guides adolescents through the digital landscape and demands that social media platforms account for adolescent well-being.

Another ethical theory that can evaluate the problem and proposed solution is Kantianism. This theory falls under the umbrella of "duty-based" ethics, which essentially says

that we should do the right thing because it is the right thing to do (Duty-Based Ethics, 2014). With Kant's view, the idea of "doing the right thing" holds, but with the aspect of good will (Duty-Based Ethics, 2014). This means that we ought to help adolescents with the problem of social media because of the good it does for them. Furthermore, the exploitation of adolescents by social media platforms violates Kant's Categorical Imperative. The second part of this imperative says that humans should always be treated as an end, never a means. As social media provides a platform that exploits the nature of the developing adolescent brain, which then increases the time spent on the platform (the overall goal of social media), adolescents are used as a means, violating this theory. The solution still holds as we are rational beings, so we should do this good thing. Thus, with the problem and solution evaluated and verified with ethical theories, the solution can be explained in greater detail.

The solution to the problem of social media use affecting adolescent development comes in two parts. The first part consists of teaching adolescents in a workshop format how to use social media and create healthy habits. This would require several volunteers to lead these class-like workshops and spaces to host the workshops. They would go over many ideas that were covered in this essay, like how it affects their development, inhibits their ability to create and sustain relationships, and can lead to feelings of anxiety and depression. The papers cited in this essay would provide excellent reading to supplement this workshop and give concrete examples and thoughts as to why social media causes these issues. The workshops would also directly teach healthy habits with social media. An example of this could be setting time limits on the apps so adolescents do not create a habitual link to the reinforcement the app gives them. The purpose of doing these workshops would be to stop the issue at the source. By showing adolescents how excess or incorrect use of social media leads to negative feelings and

development, they would be less likely to engage in these actions. The ideas the adolescents learn in this workshop could be applied to other aspects of their lives, passed on to their friends, or taught to other generations who are also learning how to use social media. Stopping the issue by teaching adolescents healthier habits would be a cost-effective and multi-generational solution to this issue.

The other part of this solution would be incentivising or enforcing social media sites to make their interfaces less addictive. The Social Media Addiction Reduction Act of 2019 is an example of a mitigation attempt, but this has not been enough, as the problem remains. While removing autoscrolling is a good example, I think enforcing users' time spent on the application to 30 minutes per day, as outlined in the bill, would be effective at reducing the issue. Also, possible increases in parental controls or stricter time limits for users under a certain age would be effective. Reducing the time spent on the application would reduce the possibility of habitual behaviors in adolescents, thus helping the problem. However, some platforms have done well to help mitigate the comparisons between others that are very prevalent among adolescents as they develop their identity (de Rutte et al, 167). For example, Instagram allows users to not show the number of likes on a post and has removed a page that showed users what their friends liked or commented on. This part of the policy is much harder to definitively define, as there are many ways that social media can be used without consequences to development. Some of the functions are vital to the purpose of the application, like TikTok's scrolling, but some form of increased parental control or time limit would aid the issue of adolescent well-being. The policy proposed to the solution still includes this as well as the workshops to teach adolescents how to use social media properly.

As previously mentioned, social media can allow adolescents to grow and develop their identity. It provides excellent grounds to connect people who would not have been able to meet before and explore new ideas. For members of the LGBTQ+ community, this allows people to increase their confidence in their identity. “Social media facilitates identity construction and communication” securely and discreetly, specifically for the LGBTQ+ community who might not be initially accepted by friends or family (Craig et al). Furthermore, social media within this community can be a safer space for them. People can choose the content they see and who they see, allowing them to create an inclusive space for themselves. Overall, this enhances the well-being of this group (Craig et al). However, this does not account for how they are using social media. According to the study by Craig et al., the youngest population in the study, ages 14-18, often use social media for entertainment or to “kill time”. The issue is that they are susceptible to the same problems every adolescent faces on social media. There is still a risk of a “digital addiction” or dependence on social media (Piotrowski, 93). Just because they can create safe spaces does not mean they cannot develop a habitual response to any part of social media. This is the reason why a workshop-like session for adolescents is necessary. Even if they can find friends and see content they enjoy, there will always be the risk of overuse, and they need to be taught how to create healthy habits. They are also still susceptible to the aggression of social media. While accounts can be blocked so their content is not shown, an initial confrontation likely occurs first which prompts the blocking. The initial interaction could deter users from further exploring their identity or could cause the victim of the aggression to become aggressive offline. Creating an inclusive space takes time and patience, something that adolescents are not fond of. Finally, the second part of the policy remains. The changes I wish to see in social media have to deal with its addictive components. If time limits are implemented for adolescents or set

up by parental controls, there will be no effect on how a person uses the app to interact with other people. Through direct messaging, people will connect with others; this is not what causes an addiction to social media, and nothing would be changed in the policy. Users will still be able to moderate the people and content they see, so they can still create a safe space online for themselves. Because all adolescents are at risk of the developmental detriments of social media, and the positive aspects of social media aren't addictive, the motivation for the policy remains intact.

Social media has proven to be a worthy source of entertaining content, greater socialization, and news. It has the power to expose users to a new side of the world that is not possible to find offline. However, we can see that the risks for adolescents can be severe. While they are learning about the world, themselves, and how to interact with others, they also need to learn about the online world. Adolescents may be more skilled in technology use than other generations, but they are at a vital stage in their development as a human and prolonged use of social media could prove to be costly. That is why this policy is needed: for the safety of adolescents. As shown through the ethics of care, it is our responsibility as independent and autonomous humans to guide the dependent humans through this unknown landscape. It is necessary for us to not just say it is bad, but teach them how to safely interact with these platforms. It is also necessary for the platforms themselves to look out for adolescents. Using the adolescent mind to increase the number of minutes spent on the app is unethical through the ethics of care and Kant. Thus, the media platforms also have an obligation to change for the safety of adolescents. Without these changes, it is unknown how this will redefine childhood for future generations, or how their interactions, development, and relationships will change.

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